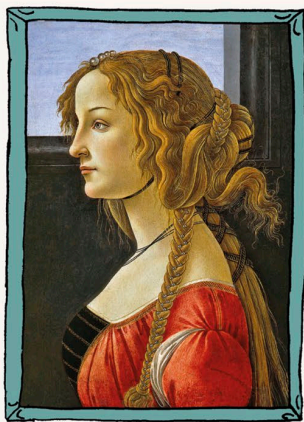


Several aspects of the painting were unusual. At this time, most Italian portraits were drawn from the side in profile or straight on from the front. But Leonardo painted the *Mona Lisa* as a three-quarter view from the front. He also set the figure against an imaginary landscape rather than against the wall of a room, which was more common. The landscape itself was noteworthy because of the amount of detail it contained. There was a winding road, some greenery, a bridge, and a river, as well as far-off icy mountains. No one place in Italy actually contained such a view, but it certainly represented aspects of the Italian countryside.

The soft curves of the background were echoed in Lisa's face and expression.



Profile portrait by
Sandro Botticelli

DID YOU KNOW?

This three-quarter view soon became so popular that many portraits have been painted that way ever since.